

tooting a friendly salute as it passes. You can walk from one end of downtown to the other in ten minutes or so, with time to greet people and catch up on gossip.

Vicki and I went to see a realtor there. We told him we were retired and thinking of moving to Mount Olive. Did he have a house for us? Maybe three bedrooms, big front porch, lots of trees in the backyard? Someplace near town, where we could walk to buy groceries, cash a check, or eat.

He nodded. "How much do you want to spend?"

I hesitated. I had heard about \$30,000 houses in North Carolina. But they couldn't be as gracious as what we'd seen. If I mentioned \$30,000, he'd think I was one taco short of a full combination plate.

I gulped. "Maybe \$50,000?"

He smiled. "That makes it easy, Mr. Terhorst. For \$50,000 you can buy this whole town."

We laughed. He was kidding. But he did have several listings for houses between \$25,000 and \$30,000. "This city can only support a few houses worth more than \$50,000," he said. "The demand isn't there."

We asked him to describe the \$30,000 houses he had listed. "Most are here in town. You get more house for your money in town than on a couple of acres of farmland. The houses seem right for a couple like yourselves: brick, two or three bedrooms, one or two baths, and big yards. They won't impress your friends. But they're easy to maintain and easy to secure when you travel."

Rand McNally's 1987 *Retirement Places Rated*, by Richard Boyer and David Savageau, ranks over 100 retirement spots in the United States. Boyer and Savageau searched for places with good climate, low-cost housing, low cost of living, low crime rate, good health care, and things to do. They wrote the book for "normal" retirees aged 55 and above. But low-cost living, a healthy place to live, and low crime appeals to us 35-year-olds as well.

The best five places they found are Murray-Kentucky Lake,